

only elite buyers and professionals.

The winners in each of the three categories we divided the computers into are as follows:

Budget category

For those who are concerned with getting a decently configured computer to let them get by with conventional applications used in the home and office, these sub-Rs 35,000 machines proved to be worthy performers in office and other day-to-day applications.

The winner in this category was the **Nebula Qmax Triad** scoring a very respectable 46.13 per cent in the overall reckoning. Based upon a Coppermine 933 processor, this machine boasted of a very good configuration, considering the price. It also managed to bag the Best Value award—it turned out to be very competitively priced as it delivered best-of-class performance compared to similarly priced systems which performed nearly 30 per cent lower. Also, with a very well docu-



Visualan Lavish P4: lots of storage space

mented sales and service network across the country, this system is a good buy for the price-conscious user.

Midrange category

In this category, we saw a wide variety of computers ranging from Intel to AMD processors. Here, the Best Performance award went to the **Visualan Lavish P4** with an overall score of 63.67. The good scores could be attributed to the high quality of system components such as the hard disk



Visualan Lavish PIII: a good choice of components

and the processor. Of special mention here is the Dart Emerald P4, which came in just a shade behind the Visualan Lavish P4.

The Best Value award went to the **Visualan Lavish PIII**. This computer was also very well configured with a 40 GB hard disk and scored respectably across the various suites.

Performance category

Finally, in the Rs 50,000+ category, there were just five players. These systems represented the pinnacle in terms of the choice of system components and performance.

The clear winner here was the **Dell Dimension 8100**. What was special about this system was the exotic choice of components. Configured completely off their Web site, this computer featured system components that are otherwise not available in the country, such as the sound-



Dell Dimension 8100: the GeForce3 at work

card, graphics accelerator, etc. These high-end components contributed to the brilliant performance of this machine. Coupled with the excellent styling and build quality, this machine had little competition and is a great choice for the power user looking for sturdy build quality and best-of-class performance.

The Best Value honours went to the **Amdell Monster PC1400**. Based upon the formidable 1.4 GHz Athlon and using the latest in motherboard and memory architecture, this system was very



Amdell Monster PC 1400: excellent speed for audio ripping

finely honed to performance. In spite of the TNT2 M64 graphics card, the machine delivered top-notch performance but lacked the graphics horsepower. However, the rest of the system was very rich in specifications with DVD, a good set of speakers and Ethernet capability.

Operating System Requirements		
When buying a branded system, you usually have the choice of which operating system you want installed on your computer. Before deciding on one, you should make sure that your computer's configuration can support the operating system with the applications you'll be using. Otherwise, you might load the latest operating system to discover that your computer does not have the power to run your applications.		
Operating System	Minimum system requirements suggested by the company	Realistic minimum system requirements
Windows XP Professional	300 Mhz processor, 128 MB RAM, 1.5 GB hard disk space, SVGA display (800x600), CD/DVD drive	500 MHz processor, 256 MB RAM, 4 GB hard disk space, XGA (1024x768), CD/DVD drive, Direct3D-capable video card
Windows Me	Pentium 150, 32 MB RAM, 295 MB hard disk space, VGA display	P-II 300 MHz processor, 128 MB RAM, 600 MB hard disk, VGA display
Windows 98SE	486DX/66 MHz or higher processor, 24 MB RAM, 315 MB hard disk space, VGA display (640x480)	200 MHz processor, 64 MB RAM, 540 MB hard disk space, VGA display
Windows 2000 Professional	Pentium 133 MHz, 32 MB RAM, 650 MB hard disk space, VGA display	P-III 500 MHz, 128 MB RAM, 1 GB hard disk space, XGA display
Windows 2000 Server	Pentium 133 MHz, 256 MB RAM, 1GB hard disk space, VGA display	P-III 500 MHz, 384 MB RAM, 2 GB hard disk space, XGA display
Red Hat Linux	486DX/66 MHz or higher processor, 24 MB RAM, 315 MB hard disk space, VGA display (640x480)	P-II 300 MHz, 64 MB RAM, 500 MB hard disk, VGA display